The southern Shan State is also the host to some influential political actors such as the NLD and the 88 Generation Group, which are closely linked to the CSOs in the Pa-O community. The military-established USDP has a presence too.[7] Also in the mix are non-state actors such as Myanmar Egress and MPC. Although holding the banner of promoting peace, not everyone in the pro-democracy camp trusts these groups.[8]

It is apparent that some of the political actors in Pa-O and southern Shan State have firm agendas opposed to the state. Therefore, in terms of pacifying the frontier by decentralization as Wong discusses in relation to the Philippines, those groups that were more pragmatic and showed less concern for democracy were co-opted. In the Pa-O community, the PNO and PNLO were not really championing democracy, they just demanded self-determination, and therefore, potentially both could be co-optation candidates. However, since the PNLO had a communist background, the regime favoured the PNO.[9] The situation in the southern Shan State is much more complicated. Since the SNLD was one of the victims in the 1990 election renunciation, it was obviously not on the regime's co-optation list. However, the RCSS/SSA-S was not a suitable candidate either. Despite reaching a ceasefire agreement, fighting continued in the northern Shan State because both sides wanted to maintain their control of vital border areas. Therefore, the regime did not find a suitable local partner until the SNDP was established in 2010.

As a quick summary, most of the actors in Pa-O areas and southern Shan State can be divided into two camps, the pre-2011 pro-regime camp, which after the election might be called the pro-establishment camp, and the pro-democracy camp (Table 5.1).[10]

Table 5.1. The pro-establishment camp versus pro-democracy camp, southern Shan State

	pro-establishment	pro-democracy
Pa-O Community	PNO	UPNO
	PDN	KRSAN; DEMO; PYO
	PNLO	
Southern Shan State	SNDP; USDP	NLD; SNLD; 88 Group
	Myanmar Egress; Myanmar Peace Center	